

Amphibians

Amphibians are animals that spend their lives partly in water and partly on land. They evolved from fish about 370 million years ago as fins slowly turned into fully formed legs that allowed them to walk on land. Amphibians were the first four-legged animals (“tetrapods”) and the ancestors of all four-legged animals alive today, from frogs and mice to elephants and humans.

Ichthyostega

ICK-thee-oh-STAY-gah

- **When** 370 million years ago (Late Devonian)
- **Fossil location** Greenland
- **Habitat** Shallow northern seas
- **Length** About 5 ft (1.5 m)

Ichthyostega's head, body, and tail fin were like those of a fish, but it had webbed feet like a frog's. It used lungs to breathe on land and had strong shoulder muscles that supported its weight out of water and helped it to crawl around. It hunted for fish and other prey in shallow pools.



Fossilized foot

Microbrachis

MY-crow-BRACK-iss

- **When** 300 million years ago (Early Permian)
- **Fossil location** Czech Republic
- **Habitat** Swamps of eastern Europe
- **Length** Almost 6 in (15 cm)

Microbrachis (below) looked like a tiny salamander with puny limbs. It had gills for breathing in water and probably swam like a fish, propelling itself forward by swishing its flattened tail from side to side. It seems to have spent most of its time in swamps, rivers, lakes, and ponds, where it hunted for prey such as small fish and shrimp.



Seymouria

see-MORE-ee-ah

- **When** 290 million years ago (Early Permian)
- **Fossil location** USA, Germany
- **Habitat** Swamps of N. America and western Europe
- **Length** About 2 ft (60 cm)

For many years *Seymouria* was believed to have been an early reptile because it had sturdy legs and was well suited to life on land. However, scientists discovered that a close relative of *Seymouria* had external gills in early life, like a tadpole, which suggests *Seymouria* did too. Although adults lived on land, youngsters probably lived entirely in water. The adult males had thick skulls that may have been used to butt rivals in mating contests.



Phlegethontia

FLEH-gch-THON-tee-ah

- **When** 300 million years ago (Late Carboniferous to Early Permian)
- **Fossil location** USA, Czech Republic
- **Habitat** Swamps of N. America and western Europe
- **Length** About 3 ft (0.9 m)

Phlegethontia belonged to a group of amphibians that had evolved snakelike bodies and lost their legs. It had rows of small, spiked teeth similar to those found in some nonvenomous snakes.



Microbrachis